

Differentiation of self, anxiety, triangling and distress: A test of Bowen theory

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Abstract

Based in Bowen theory (Kerr, 2019; Kerr & Bowen, 1988), this study examined differentiation of self as a moderator of the relationship between anxiety and current triangling among a sample of adolescents. It also explored the relationship between specific triangle subtypes and psychological symptoms. We hypothesized that higher levels of anxiety would be associated with higher levels of triangling, and that this relationship would be weaker for participants who report higher levels of differentiation of self. Additionally, we hypothesized that psychological symptoms would be significantly lower for those who indicated a balanced triangle configuration to characterize their family structure (as compared to those selecting scapegoating, cross-generational coalition or mediator patterns). Results partially supported our hypotheses; differentiation performed as a moderator in two analyses, but not in others. Higher levels of psychological symptoms were associated with experience with mediator and cross-generational triangling.

KEYWORDS

anxiety, bowen theory, differentiation of self, triangling

DIFFERENTIATION OF SELF, ANXIETY, TRIANGLING AND DISTRESS: A TEST OF BOWEN THEORY

Triangles have been described as the “... smallest stable emotional unit” in family relationships (Kerr & Bowen, 1988, p. 134). According to Bowen family systems theory, a person experiences a triangle, or triangling, when two people in relationship experience stress or tension between themselves and subsequently involve a third person in the system in order to reduce anxiety. Although triangles are constantly forming, dissolving, and reforming in families, Bowen asserted that when people became stuck in a particular triangle, with the triangle rigidly constraining the behavior of the participants,

Author Note Romana C. Bresin is now at The Wellness Center at Rowan University, Glassboro, NJ. Results presented in this manuscript were new analyses of data collected for the third author's dissertation research under the supervision of the first author.

negative consequences would be likely, including psychological symptoms in the triangled third person (Kerr & Bowen, 1988).

A commonly observed triangle is among parents (or parental figures) and a child, which is the focus of this investigation. In general, persistent triangling has been found to correlate with negative outcomes for both children and adolescents (Bosco et al., 2003; Perrin et al., 2013; Wang & Crane, 2001). However, triangles are thought to take several different forms, which may possibly relate to specific psychosocial outcomes. Bell et al. (2001) proposed that four different triangle configurations are observed in families – balanced, mediator, cross-generational coalition, and scapegoat – illustrating that children are either “pushed out” or “pulled in” by their parental figures. With the exception of the balanced subtype, in which family members are psychologically equidistant from one another (Bell et al., 2001), these configurations have been associated with largely negative outcomes (Afifi & Schrodtt, 2003; Kerig, 1995; Smalley et al., 2017; Wang et al., 2017; Yahav & Sharlin, 2002).

However, Bowen proposed a more complex relationship between differentiation of self (DoS), a person's capacity to balance the pulls of both emotional autonomy and togetherness in one's family of origin anxiety, and outcomes. Specifically, Kerr and Bowen (1988) predicted a potential buffering effect of DoS on the relationship between anxiety and triangling, arguing that the overall level of differentiation moderates the frequency and intensity of triangling, such that families and individuals higher in DoS can tolerate higher levels of anxiety and are less likely to be involved in triangles than are those lower in differentiation (Kerr & Bowen, 1988). Despite these assertions, few studies to date have examined the relations among anxiety, triangling, and DoS. The purpose of this study was to examine the potential moderating effect of differentiation on the relationship between anxiety and current level of triangling of adolescents into a parent's relationship, and to also assess triangle sub-types in relation to psychological outcomes.

Triangling

Triangling is often referenced in various family systems theories and is thought to occur when two individuals in a family experience some degree of anxiety or conflict between them as a result of balancing the pulls of togetherness and separateness; it is typically the loss of family members' unique identities coupled with the pull of togetherness that lead to “encroaching on one another and functioning at one another's expense” (Kerr & Bowen, 1988, p. 94). As a way to decrease that tension, they pull in a third member (Kerr, 2019; Kerr & Bowen, 1988). Triangling occurs in all families and is thought to distribute the anxiety throughout the system – the anxiety is siphoned into three relationships rather than funneled into just one. Bowen theory distinguishes between two kinds of anxiety, acute anxiety, which is a time-limited response to real threats, and chronic anxiety, or anxiety that is learned early in development and primarily associated with relationship disruptions (Kerr, 2019; Kerr & Bowen, 1988). In essence, two-person systems remain relatively stable only as long as chronic anxiety is low. According to Bowen theory, low levels of anxiety are challenging to maintain, particularly in families with low levels of differentiation, who are less adaptive in the face of stress, which raises chronic anxiety and makes them more susceptible to triangling. Once a pattern of triangling has been established in a family, “it tends to stick” (Bell et al., 2001, p. 176). These rigid and persistent triangles are thought to lead to negative outcomes for all individuals in the triangle, but particularly the third person drawn into the triangle, often a child or adolescent, because it is assumed that tension in a parental relationship is relieved, but the involvement of the adolescent in the parental relationship often results in symptoms. Because we are at the beginning phases of investigation with regard to the effects of different types of family triangling, we focus on current triangles involving one child, in our case, late adolescents, and two parental figures.

Triangle types

Bell et al. (2001) proposed that four different triangle configurations can be observed in child–parent relationships: balanced, mediator, cross-generational coalition, and scapegoat. *Balanced* is nearest

to what Bowen would have deemed “healthy,” whereby the parents and child all have an equidistant relationship from one another (Bell et al., 2001). The child's needs are being met accordingly and the parents are resolving their differences independently. The *mediator* and *cross-generational* coalition subtypes each involve “pulling in” the child. In the *mediator* configuration, children find themselves caught in the middle of their parents and are typically closer to each of them than the parents are to one another. In *cross-generational* coalition, rather than being in the middle, the child is pulled closer to one parent to form an alliance. In the *scapegoat* configuration, the child is “pushed out” by their parents as a way of easing the conflict between them. The pushing out involves the parents focusing on some aspect of the child, which can be either positive or negative, resulting in stability in the parental unit. For example, concentrating on a child's athletic abilities or difficulties in school moves tension away from the parental relationship (Bell et al., 2001). Bell et al. tested these ideas in two samples of adolescents and their parents from the United States and Japan, although due to data collection procedures, some hypotheses could only be tested in one of the samples. They found that among the U.S. sample, Bowen's ideas about stressed parents triangling children were supported. Patterns of triangling across samples seemed to be similar, with boys more likely to be scapegoated and girls pulled into the mediator or cross generational coalition configurations. Links between all types of triangling and ego development were also similar across samples, with girls who were in other than balanced configurations showing lower levels of ego development. No such relationship was found for boys in either sample.

The impact of triangling

The literature has primarily focused on the negative effects of triangling with parents on children and adolescents. Several studies have identified that triangling in one's family of origin is significantly and positively associated with child depression (Wang & Crane, 2001), poor ego development (Bell et al., 2001), relational anxiety and negative adjustment (Perrin et al., 2013), as well as externalizing problem behaviors (Bosco et al., 2003). Although this diffusion of boundaries occurs more often in divorced families (Valls-Vidal et al., 2016), triangling between parents and children has been significantly linked to negative outcomes for those from both divorced and intact families (Perrin et al., 2013). Although patterns of triangling across cultures and other dimensions of diversity are understudied, for the most part these negative effects are observed across diverse samples (Bell et al., 2001; Kwok et al., Valls-Vidal et al., 2016; Wang et al., 2017) although Wang et al found a positive relationship between parentification (which they considered a form of triangling) among a sample of Chinese elementary students. Some research has found that patterns of triangling differ across gender (e.g., Bell et al., 2001; Wang et al., 2017), but other studies have not shown gender differences (Franck & Buehler, 2007; Grych et al., 2004).

The negative impact of triangling appears to have long-term effects that extend beyond early adolescence. Benson et al. (1993) examined the long-term impact of triangling and fusion on late adolescent romantic relationships. They found that experiencing triangling in one's family of origin was significantly related to aversive communication (withdrawing, badgering, rejecting) in later romantic relationships. Smith et al. (1998) found that higher levels of triangling in students' families of origin predicted lower levels of college adjustment.

The types of triangling individuals experience are also thought to be linked to specific outcomes and some data supports this assumption. For instance, although Minuchin et al. (1978) stated there is always involvement of the child in the parents' relationship in families in which a member has been diagnosed with anorexia, a qualitative study demonstrated that those with anorexia reported specifically being involved in cross-generational coalitions with their mothers while often isolating and displaying anger towards their fathers (Smalley et al., 2017). Additionally, families that engaged in cross-generational coalitions were found to experience higher marital discord and negative affect in comparison to those in which scapegoating was observed. Scapegoated children, on the other hand,

reported more self-blame than those in cross-generational coalitions (Kerig, 1995). Children with externalizing symptoms described being scapegoated more often by their families in comparison to a non-symptomatic control group and an internalizing symptoms group (Yahav & Sharlin, 2002).

Despite these nuances, there is also a great deal of overlap in the negative effects of various types of triangling. Both scapegoating and cross-generational coalitions were related to worse outcomes for children including poorer school adjustment and higher levels of depression (Wang et al., 2017). For those from married families, feeling “caught in the middle” (indicating both mediator and cross-generational coalitions) of parents' discord was related to poor relational adjustment (Perrin et al., 2013). In a similar vein, the relationship between the impact of divorce and relationship quality with parents, as measured by adolescents' discontent with and avoidance of parents, was largely mediated by children's perceptions of being caught between their parents (Afifi & Schrodt, 2003). Adolescents who felt more caught between their parents were significantly more likely to avoid them. Finally, Bell et al. (2001) found that girls in balanced family structures (assumably non-triangled) demonstrated stronger ego development than those in scapegoat, cross-generational coalition, and mediator configurations. Overall, the literature supports the negative impact of triangling on the individual experiencing it, specifically when the triangle configuration involves scapegoating, cross-generational coalition, or mediating.

Differentiation of self

Bowen posited that all individuals experience an instinctual push and pull of emotionally separating from one's family of origin and remaining emotionally connected to them (Kerr & Bowen, 1988). This process of differentiation of self in relation to the family of origin involves an individual maintaining a distinct sense of self while also engaging in close relationships. DoS is composed of four components: emotional cutoff, fusion with others, emotional reactivity, and I position (Kerr & Bowen, 1988; Skowron & Friedlander, 1998). Emotional cutoff entails engaging in distancing, isolation, and feeling threatened by intimacy. Conversely, fusion is categorized by emotional over involvement with others; separation feels threatening for individuals high in fusion. Emotionally reactive individuals find it difficult to distinguish between thoughts and feelings, making it challenging to remain composed when faced with their own and others' anxiety. According to Bowen, those capable of taking an I position uphold a strong sense of self and maintain their convictions even when pressured to alter them. A highly differentiated individual will demonstrate low emotional cutoff, low levels of fusion, low emotional reactivity, and an ability to take and maintain an I position.

Bowen proposed that DoS moderated the relationship between stress and levels of well-being. Kerr and Bowen (1988) noted that “people at *any* point on the scale (of differentiation), if stressed sufficiently, can develop physical, emotional, or social symptoms” (p.97). DoS has been shown to be negatively related to many forms of psychological distress, including anxiety (Skowron & Friedlander, 1998), interpersonal problems (Choi & Murdock, 2016), psychological dysfunction, (Murdock & Gore Jr., 2004), and is positively related to well-being (Bartle-Haring & Lal, 2010). Much of the literature has supported a direct relationship between DoS and distress, but the proposed moderation has been less frequently documented. However, (Murdock & Gore Jr., 2004) assessed how DoS and perceived stress interacted, demonstrating that low differentiated people experiencing significant levels of stress reported significantly higher levels of psychological symptoms than more highly differentiated people experiencing comparable stress levels, thus supporting Bowen's moderation hypothesis.

Differentiation of self, anxiety, and triangling

In this study, we were specifically concerned with chronic anxiety because it is theorized to be closely related to relational functioning. As chronic anxiety increases in a family system, individuals become

less adaptive in responding to stressful events. Eventually, chronic anxiety can exceed a person's adaptive capabilities such that "a person's anxious response to stress impairs his (*sic*) own functioning and/or the functioning of those with whom he is emotionally connected" (Kerr & Bowen, 1988, p. 112). Chronic anxiety decreases individuals' levels of physical, emotional, and social functioning, which fuels the formation of triangles as a way to stabilize the family unit. Bowen ultimately proposed that DoS would affect the degree of triangling in a family. Although triangles are more likely to occur during periods of increased anxiety, the response to such anxiety is thought to be dependent on individuals' level of DoS. Kerr and Bowen (1988) hypothesized that individuals high in DoS are better able to tolerate anxiety in the family system, and are therefore less likely to become involved in triangles. Furthermore, their experiences of triangling are less likely to be stable over time. On the other hand, those lower in DoS are less apt to tolerate anxiety and are more likely to be involved in long-term triangles. In essence, DoS was proposed to buffer the effects of anxiety in the family (Kerr & Bowen, 1988).

Although Bowen theorized about the relations among anxiety, DoS, and triangling, to our knowledge, no studies have tested this hypothesis. Peleg (2014) included all three variables in testing three hypotheses: (a) Exposure to stressful events in childhood would be associated with lower DoS, (b) stressful life events in childhood would positively correlate with intergenerational triangling in later adulthood, and (c) DoS would be related to higher levels of intergenerational triangling. Peleg's results largely supported these hypotheses. However, this study tested the impact of stress, rather than anxiety, on the development of triangles and did not test the moderation hypothesis.

The current study

In this study, we tested two predictions derived from Bowen Family Systems theory. First, we examined the association between anxiety and current triangling in adolescents' relations with parental figures, and then tested the potential buffering effect that might result from higher levels of DoS. For this purpose, we tested the relationships among differentiation, anxiety, and two measures of triangling, the TRI, which assesses 4 patterns of triangling, and the Intergenerational Triangulation subscale of the Personal Authority in the Family System, a general measure of triangling (Bray & Harvey, 1992). Second, we tested the relationships between types of current triangling and psychological symptoms by examining both the relations among triangle types as assessed by the TRI and by having participants choose one of the triangle configurations identified by Bell et al. (2001). We tested two specific hypotheses. First, we predicted a significant interaction between DoS and anxiety as predictors of triangling (i.e., the relationship between anxiety and triangling would be stronger for individuals lower in DoS while the relationship will be weaker for those higher in DoS). Secondly, we tested whether levels of psychological symptoms would be significantly lower for individuals who indicated that the *Balanced* triangle subtype was characteristic in their families, compared to those who endorsed the *Scapegoat*, *Mediator*, and *Cross-generational coalition* configurations.

METHOD

Participants

We used the data collected by Bresin et al. (2017), which consisted of a sample of 275 participants. Participants were 190 females (69.1%), 80 males (29.1%), 2 identified as other (0.7%), and 3 not responding (1.1%) who ranged in age from 18 to 23 ($M = 20.62$, $SD = 2.37$). Just over half (54.5%) the sample was White ($n = 150$), and the remaining participants identified as 20.4% Black ($n = 56$), 6.9% Asian ($n = 19$), 6.2% Latino(a)/Chicano(a)/Hispanic ($n = 17$), 5.8% Middle Eastern ($n = 16$), 0.7% International ($n = 2$), 4.7% Biracial or Multiracial ($n = 13$), and 0.7% not responding ($n = 2$).

The majority of the sample identified as heterosexual (90.5%, $n = 249$), and 2.6% identified as gay or lesbian, 5.5% bisexual, 1.1% other; 0.4% were missing this information. Most were currently enrolled as college undergraduates (96.4%, $n = 264$), whereas 1.5% identified themselves as master's degree students ($n = 4$), 1.5% as doctoral students ($n = 4$), and 0.7% indicated a different level of education ($n = 2$). In regards to family structure, most (60.5%) reported that their parents were married, 10.5% separated, 23.3% divorced, 4.7% cohabiting, and 0.7% did not respond. Only children comprised 8% of the sample ($n = 22$), 31.3% had one sibling ($n = 86$), 24.0% had two siblings ($n = 66$), 16% had three siblings ($n = 44$), 20.4% had four or more siblings ($n = 56$), and 0.4% were missing ($n = 1$).

Measures

Differentiation of self

The Differentiation of Self Inventory – Short Form (DSI-SF; Drake et al., 2015) was used to measure differentiation of self in relation to family of origin. The DSI-SF is a condensed 20-item version of the 46-item Differentiation of Self Inventory – Revised (DSI-R; Skowron & Schmitt, 2003). Participants rated items on a five-point scale, where 1 means “*Not at all characteristic of me*,” and 5 means “*Very characteristic of me*.” Higher scores indicate higher levels of DoS. Example items include, “I tend to distance myself when people get close to me” and “I often agree with others just to appease them.” The DSI-SF has of four subscales: Emotional Cutoff (EC; 3 items), Emotional Reactivity (ER; 6 items), Fusion with Others (FO; 5 items) and I-Position (IP; 6 items). Because there are a varying number of items per scale, scores are averaged for both the subscale total and the full-scale total. Drake et al. (2015) found a strong internal consistency estimate for the full DSI-SF scale (0.88) and adequate internal consistency for the four subscales: EC, 0.79; ER, 0.80; FO, 0.68; and IP, 0.70. The fusion subscale specifically had lower internal consistency compared to the others. The authors asserted, however, that it performed adequately when included in the full-scale measure. For the purpose of this study, a full scale score was used. Drake et al. (2015) reported a significant, positive relationship between the DSI-SF and the Level of Differentiation of Self Scale (Haber, 2003) as evidence of convergent validity, a four-week test–retest reliability of $r = 0.85$, as well as strong stability coefficients for each of the four subscales ($r = 0.72$ – 0.84). Cronbach's alpha for this study was 0.93 for the full scale.

Triangling

Three measures of triangling were used in this research. First, The Triangular Relationship Inventory (TRI; Bresin et al., 2017) is a 24-item stand-alone measure of triangling. Individuals rate items on a five-point scale ranging from 1, *Strongly Disagree*, to 5, *Strongly Agree*. In the development of this measure, triangling was operationally defined as “intergenerational, the current involvement of an adolescent in his or her parental figures' conflicts, disagreements, or relationship. The adolescent can also be triangled into his or her parental figures' relationship by being the positive or negative focus of the parental relationship” (Bresin et al., 2017, p. 7). Participants were instructed to think about the current state of their relationship dynamics with two parental figures and indicate the level to which they agreed with each item. Example items include “Both of my parents use me to communicate,” and “My parents are more invested in my problems than their own.” Higher scores are an indication of higher levels of triangling. The TRI consists of four subscales, all of which are composed of six items, measuring the different types of triangle configurations including *Balanced*, *Mediator*, *Scapegoat*, and *Cross-Generational Coalition*. The balanced subscale items are reverse coded to reflect that a higher level of balance indicates unbalanced, or assumedly unhealthy relationships. Total scores are summed across items. Bresin et al. (2017) found evidence of strong internal consistency with Cronbach's alpha coefficients of 0.95 for the TRI full scale, as well as for the four triangle subscales: Balanced, 0.96,

Mediator, 0.92, Scapegoat, 0.89, and Cross-generational coalition, 0.87. The TRI's large, negative correlation ($r = -0.62$) with the Intergenerational Triangulation subscale (INTRI) provided evidence of sound construct validity (higher scores on the INTRI indicate lower levels of triangling; Bresin et al., 2017). At a four-week follow up, the TRI full scale demonstrated a test-retest reliability of $r = 0.76$. Cronbach's alphas for the full and subscale scores in this study are shown in Table 1.

The Intergenerational Triangulation subscale of the Personal Authority in the Family Systems Questionnaire (INTRI) subscale was also used to assess perceptions of triangling among adolescents and young adults about their families of origin, specifically, with their parents or parental figures (Bray & Harvey, 1992). The INTRI is an 8-item, self-report measure on a Likert-type scale that ranges from 1 *all of the time* to 5 *never*, with higher scores indicating less triangling. Examples of items include: "When your parents disagree, how often do you feel "caught in the middle" between them?" and "It feels like I cannot get emotionally close to my father without moving away from my mother," (Bray et al., 1984). Evidence for construct validity of the INTRI subscale was provided by Brossart et al. (2006), who demonstrated that the INTRI items loaded on the same factor in a large factor analysis. Bray and Harvey (1992) reported a test-retest coefficient for the INTRI of 0.66, indicating that the rapid developmental changes among adolescents would contribute to slightly lower reliability over time. Cronbach's alpha reliability in the current sample was 0.78.

Triangling depiction

This study also analyzed the data gathered by Bresin et al. using a visual measure of current triangling in the family of origin. In that study, participants were shown the depictions of the four triangle types in Bell et al.'s Figure 1 and were asked to indicate which triangle best resembled their family structure. Participants were given the instructions "using the two individuals you identified as primary parental figures and yourself, choose the diagram that most closely resembles your family structure or dynamic, keeping in mind that shorter lines represent closer relationships and long lines indicate more distant relationships." Triangle configurations included balanced, scapegoat, mediator, and cross-generational coalition. At present, there is no information on the validity or reliability of this measure.

Anxiety

The State-Trait Inventory for Cognitive and Somatic Anxiety (STICSA; Grös et al., 2007) is a 21-item self-report measure with two subscales to evaluate cognitive (10 items) and somatic symptoms of anxiety (11 items). The STICSA State scale assesses how respondents feel at the present moment while the STICSA Trait scale asks respondents "how often, in general, the statement is true of you" (Grös et al., 2007, p. 370). Both scales contain the same 21 items and are answered on a four-point scale where 1 means *Not at all* and 4 means *Very much so*. The following are example items: "I feel agonized over my problems," and "My heart beats fast." Grös et al. (2007) reported expected correlations between STICSA and other measures of anxiety. Grös et al. (2007) found evidence of strong internal consistency with Cronbach alpha coefficients of 0.87 for the STICSA Trait subscales and 0.88 for the STICSA State subscale. Excellent alpha reliability coefficients for both the State (0.94) and Trait (0.93) scales were observed in our sample. For the purpose of this study, the STICSA Trait total score was used, as it is a measure of more general, chronic anxiety, which Bowen theorized has the strongest influence on relationship dynamics. Scores are summed across the Cognitive Trait Anxiety and Somatic Trait Anxiety subscales with higher scores indicating higher anxiety.

Psychological symptoms

The Hopkins Symptoms Checklist-21 (HSCL-21; Green et al., 1988) is a 21-item shortened version of the 58-item Hopkins Symptoms Checklist. Items are rated on a four-point scale ranging from 1, *Not at all* to 4, *Extremely*. Participants indicate the distress they have felt over the past 7 days on items such as "trouble concentrating," "weakness in parts of your body," and "feeling inferior to others." Higher

scores indicate higher distress. The HSCL-21 contains three subscales: General Feelings of Distress (GFD), Performance Difficulty (PD), Somatic Distress (SD). Scores are summed across the three subscales. Green et al. (1988) reported an internal consistency coefficient of 0.90 for the full scale. In the current sample, Cronbach's alpha was 0.93. Because this study was not seeking to differentiate between types of symptoms, the full-scale score was used.

PROCEDURE

Participants were recruited from an urban Midwestern university, as well as email listserves, online forums, and through Facebook. They were informed that the purpose of the study was to investigate the relationship between stress management and family dynamics. The research was reviewed and approved by the university's institutional review board. Interested participants were provided with a link that directed them to an online survey; clicking the link was considered consent. Demographic items and the TRI measure were presented first. At the end of the demographics section, participants were asked to identify two primary parental figures and instructed to answer the remaining measures while thinking about these individuals. To control for possible order effects, surveys were counterbalanced. After completing the survey, participants were offered the opportunity to win one out of five \$10 gift cards to [Amazon.com](https://www.amazon.com) by clicking a link that directed them to an independent website. Any contact information participants provided for the raffle was destroyed upon its completion.

RESULTS

Preliminary analyses

Preliminary data screening did not suggest problems with assumptions of normality and linearity. A missing values analysis of the 275 cases demonstrated that less than 2% of the total values were missing. A Little's Missing Completely at Random (MCAR) test was carried out and indicated that any missing data were at random, $\chi^2 = 185.64$, $p = 0.35$. Missing data was imputed utilizing the expectation maximization algorithm (Bresin et al., 2017; Tabachnick & Fidell, 2007). Prior to forming a product term to represent an interaction between DSI-SF and STICSA-T scores on both variables were centered by subtracting the sample mean. Levene's test indicated that there were no violations regarding the homogeneity of variance assumption across groups. Examination of a histogram of psychological symptom scores indicated that scores were approximately normally distributed with two extreme outliers (exceeding 3 standard deviations), which were subsequently removed.

Main analyses

Table 1 displays the correlations and other descriptive statistics for the variables in this study. In order to test the hypothesis that there would be a significant interaction between differentiation of self and anxiety as predictors of triangling, a hierarchical multiple regression was first performed using the INTRI scores as the outcome variable. Table 2 shows the results of this analysis. In Step 1, DSI-SF and STICSA-T scores were entered. In Step 2, the interaction term, DSI-SF x STICSA-T, was entered. The overall regression was statistically significant, $R = 0.316$, $R^2 = 0.10$, $F(3, 224) = 8.29$, $p < 0.001$. Table 2 presents the results, which indicated that DSI-SF ($\beta = 0.39$, $p < 0.01$) and STICSA-T ($\beta = -0.25$, $p < 0.01$) significantly predicted levels of triangling. Analysis revealed the change in R^2 was significant for the final step of the regression ($\Delta R^2 = 0.02$, $p < 0.05$) and that the interaction between DSI-SF and STICSA-T was statistically significant ($\beta = -0.33$, $p < 0.05$). In short, these analyses indicated that higher DoS and lower STICSA-T predicted lower levels of triangling. The interaction between DSI and STICSA-T was also supported, such that the anxiety was a stronger

TABLE 1 Distributional statistics, Cronbach's alpha reliabilities, and intercorrelations of the variables in the model ($N = 275$)

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1. TRI	0.95										
2. Balanced	0.84***	0.96									
3. Mediator	0.87***	0.68***	0.92								
4. Cross-generational	0.85***	0.64***	0.70***	0.87							
5. Scapegoat	0.64***	0.29***	0.40***	0.39***	0.89						
6. INTRI	-0.62***	-0.62***	-0.54***	-0.58***	-0.22***	0.88					
7. DSI-SF	-0.21**	-0.12*	-0.21**	-0.26***	-0.09	0.24***	0.93				
9. STICSA-Trait	0.25***	0.18**	0.28***	0.25***	0.10	-0.33***	-0.53***	0.82***	0.93		
11. HSCL-21	0.17**	0.09	0.18**	0.17**	0.12	-0.26***	-0.52***	0.78***	0.82***	-0.43***	0.93
Minimum	24	6	4.18	5.38	6	8	30	21	21	5	21
Maximum	116	30	30	30	30	40	115	80	80	35	84
M	56.33	14.12	12.32	14.00	15.88	31.35	76.78	34.27	37.31	23.45	38.78
SD	21.01	7.40	6.32	6.29	6.27	6.95	16.27	12.07	11.90	6.88	12.17
Skewness	0.37	0.56	0.71	0.35	0.29	-0.92	0.04	1.15	0.78	-0.54	0.85
Kurtosis	-0.74	-0.88	-0.61	-0.79	-0.59	0.61	-0.10	1.01	0.04	-0.25	0.54

Note: Cronbach's alphas are presented on the diagonal.

Abbreviations: DSI-SF, differentiation of self inventory - short form; HSCL-21, Hopkins symptom checklist - 21; INTRI, personal authority in the family system questionnaire intergenerational triangulation subscale; STICSA-Trait, state-trait inventory for cognitive and somatic anxiety - trait subscale; TRI, triangular relationship inventory.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.01$.

*** $p < 0.001$.

TABLE 2 Hierarchical multiple regression predicting triangling as measured by the INTRI

	ΔR^2	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	β
Step 1	0.08***			
DSI-SF		1.04	0.63	0.12
STICSA-T		−0.12	0.05	−0.19*
Step 2	0.02*			
DSI-SF		3.25	1.13	−0.39**
STICSA-T		−0.15	0.05	−0.25**
DSI-SF x STICSA-T		−0.10	0.04	−0.33*

Note: *N* = 275.
Abbreviations: DSI, differentiation of self inventory-revised short form; STICSA-T, state–trait inventory for cognitive and somatic anxiety - trait subscale.
**p* < 0.05.
***p* < 0.01.
****p* < 0.001.

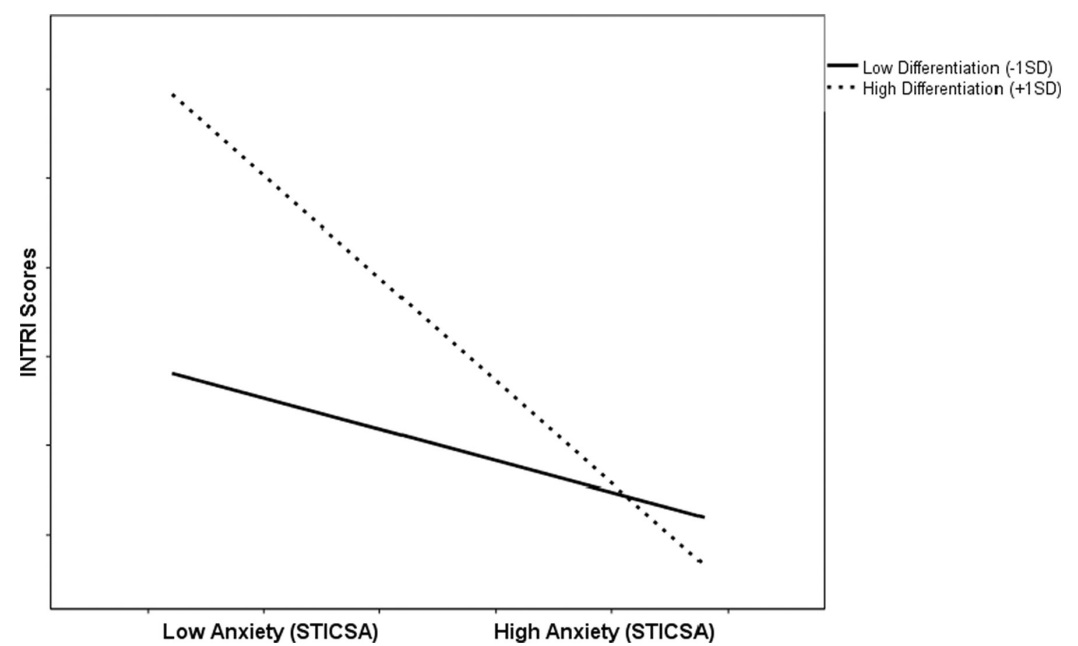


FIGURE 1 The interaction of DSI-SF and anxiety in predicting triangulation as measured by the INTRI.
Abbreviations: INTRI, Intergenerational Triangulation Inventory (higher scores = lower triangling); STICSA, State–Trait Inventory for Cognitive and Somatic Anxiety - Trait subscale.

predictor of triangling for individuals with lower levels of differentiation of self. The interaction is shown graphically in Figure 1.

Bresin et al. (2017) reported that there was good evidence for the unidimensionality of, and good internal consistency for the TRI subscales. The bivariate correlations between subscales and DSI-SF, STICAS and HCSL-21 scores were variable. These patterns led us to examine the interactions between DSI-SF x STICSA-T at the subscale instead of the full-scale level to assess the relationships between the types of triangles measured by the TRI and the other variables. Four hierarchical multiple regressions were performed with each of the TRI subscales following the steps outlined for the analysis of the INTRI scores. For the Mediator subscale the change in *R*² was significant for the second step of

the regression ($\Delta R^2 = 0.02$). The interaction term, DSI-SF x STICSA-T significantly predicted Mediator scores ($\beta = 0.32, p < 0.05$; see Table 3). The interaction is depicted graphically in Figure 2. The interaction effect only approached statistical significance for the Cross-generational coalition subscale ($\beta = 0.24, p = 0.08$) and was not statistically significant for the other two subscales.

Two approaches examined the hypothesis that mean scores on psychological symptoms would differ according to individuals' reports of the type of triangling they experienced in their families of origin. First, bivariate correlations indicated that only the Mediator and Cross-generational subscales of the TRI correlated with HCSL-21 scores at statistically significant levels ($r_s = 0.18$ and

TABLE 3 Hierarchical multiple regression predicting Triangling as measured by the TRI mediator subscale

	ΔR^2	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	β
Step 1	0.08***			
DSI-SF		−0.52	0.57	−0.07
STICSA-T		0.15	0.04	0.27**
Step 2	0.02*			
DSI-SF		−2.41	0.98	−0.32*
STICSA-T		0.15	0.04	0.30***
DSI-SFxSTICSA-T		0.08	0.03	0.32*

Note: *N* = 275.

Abbreviations: DSI, differentiation of self inventory-revised short form; STICSA-T, state–trait inventory for cognitive and somatic anxiety - trait subscale.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.01$.

*** $p < 0.001$.

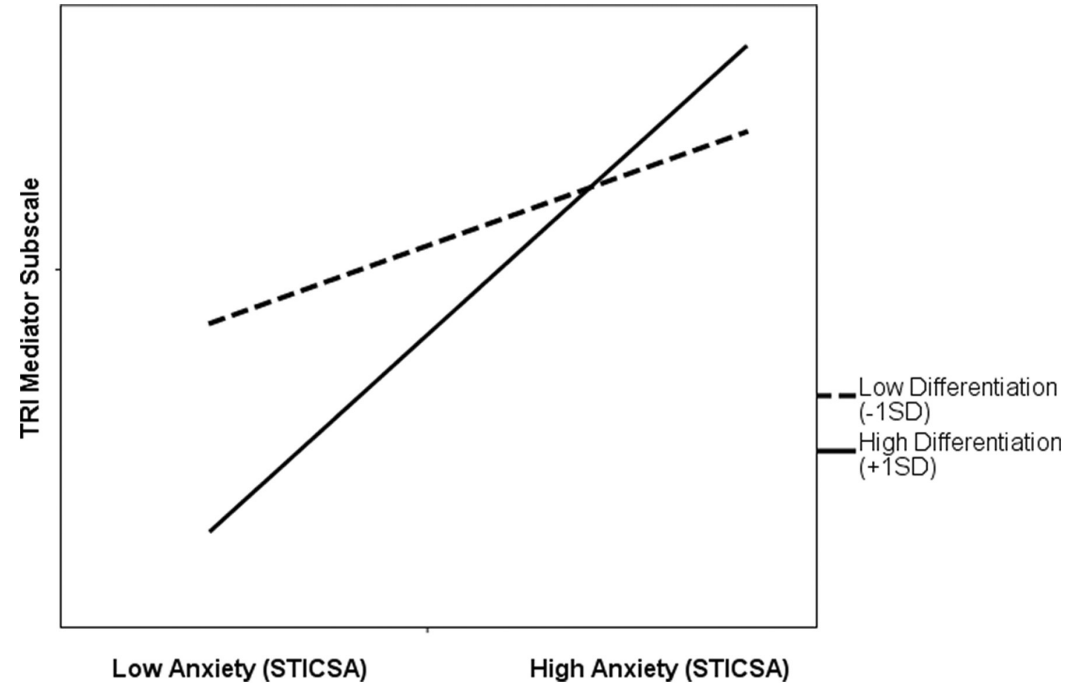


FIGURE 2 The interaction of the DSI-SF scores and anxiety in predicting mediator scores on the TRI. TRI triangular relationship inventory (higher scores = more triangling); STICSA, state–trait inventory for cognitive and somatic anxiety - trait subscale.

0.17 respectively, $p < 0.01$). A second examination involved the participants' self-identification of the primary type of triangling experienced by selecting one of the depictions of the four types. A one-way between-subjects analysis of variance (ANOVA) was performed to compare mean scores on the HSCL-21 across the triangle configurations. The ANOVA was statistically significant, $F(3, 256) = 2.93$, $p < 0.05$. The effect size was $n^2 = 0.04$, a small effect suggesting that HSCL-21 scores differed as a function of family triangle configuration. The majority of participants identified the triangle depiction best resembling their family structure as Cross-generational coalition (35.7%, $n = 93$) followed by Balanced (33.8%, $n = 88$), whereas the remaining identified their family structures as the Mediator configuration (19.2%, $n = 50$), and Scapegoat configuration (11.2%, $n = 29$), respectively.

To explore differences among the means, all possible pair wise comparisons were made using the Tukey HSD test. Results showed that the mean symptom score of the Balanced group ($M = 35.69$) was lower than the Cross-generational coalition group ($M = 40.32$, $p < 0.05$) and the Mediator group ($M = 40.12$), but the difference between Mediator and Balanced only approached statistical significance ($p = 0.07$). The Scapegoat group reported a mean level of symptoms ($M = 37.14$) that was intermediate between the other groups and did not differ significantly from the other triangle configurations.

DISCUSSION

Our results demonstrated that trait anxiety and differentiation of self were significantly related to triangling, in both measures of overall triangling and in relation to some subtypes of triangling. These patterns are consistent with previous research that has found triangling related to various forms of psychological distress (Afifi & Schrodt, 2003; Bell et al., 2001; Peleg, 2014; Wang et al., 2017). In addition, when one often-used measure of overall triangling, the INTRI (Bray & Harvey, 1992), was used as the outcome variable, the interaction of DoS and anxiety predicted triangling. An increase in triangling associated with increasing levels of anxiety was more prominent for those with lower levels of DoS, which supported Bowen's moderation hypothesis. Put another way, DoS appeared to buffer against the negative effects of anxiety in the family. As described below, our results also offered the opportunity to assess whether moderating effects differed across the different types of triangling.

Our results also offered a glimpse into the effects of the effects of four different types of triangling in terms of their associations with indicators of health and distress. For example, the Scapegoat and Balanced subscales had weak correlations with both differentiation and anxiety. The correlation between Mediator subscale scores and symptoms was twice the size of that between Balanced scores and symptoms, which was also the lowest of all four bivariate correlations. Cross-generational and Mediator patterns were the most strongly correlated with anxiety and symptoms, suggesting that these forms of triangling were the most detrimental. To be caught between or in coalition with one parent seems to be associated with more detrimental outcomes than when the adolescent is pushed out of the parental dyad (i.e., scapegoated) or feels equally connected to both parents. To our knowledge, no other studies have established relationships between these triangling subtypes and indicators of distress using a validated measure specifically designed to measure all four configurations.

From a theoretical standpoint, the unexpected weak correlations involving the Balanced and Scapegoat subscales are interesting. The Balanced subscale was reverse scored, so that higher levels indicated deviation from an equidistant, presumably healthy, parents-child configuration. This more general aspect of the TRI, although still assessing triangling, arguably reinforces the need to measure the specific types of triangling we examined in this research.

Two possible explanations can be considered to account for the weak relationships between scapegoating, anxiety, and symptoms. First, Bell et al. (2001) proposed that scapegoating, or the pushing out and subsequent focus of parents' attention on children, can be either positive or negative for the child. This broader range of potential scapegoating behaviors can be observed in the TRI's Scapegoat scale items (Breslin et al., 2017). Example items include, "My parents are more invested in my talents than their relationship with one another," and "My parents focus more on my problems rather

than difficulties in their own relationship.” Because the scale captures both the positive and negative elements of scapegoat dynamics, it may also obscure the negative effects (e.g., increased anxiety and symptoms) of certain types of scapegoating. Second, it may be that scapegoating, by definition the “pushing out” of the child, is less aversive because the child is not caught between the parents in the same ways that they are in the mediator or cross generational patterns. This speculation might be consistent with Bell et al.'s (2001) finding that among Japanese boys, who were more likely to be scapegoated, the relationship between triangling and personal development was not statistically significant. Future research is needed to fully explore the operation of the scapegoat subscale; it is possible that it would be helpful to separate out the positive and negative types of this dynamic. These results also point to a need to further explore differences in triangling across culture and gender. Although the original analysis of the data here, used in the development of the TRI, found no differences across gender, sexual orientation, or race/ethnicity (Bresin et al., 2017), the lack of differences in this one study cannot rule these out, which are sometimes found in other research (Bell et al., 2001; Peleg, 2014; Wang et al., 2017).

In tests of moderation using the subtypes of triangling, a significant interaction emerged between differentiation of self and anxiety in predicting Mediator subscale scores. The interaction term similarly approached significance when the Cross-generational coalition subscale served as the outcome variable. Nonsignificant interaction effects were observed for the Balanced and Scapegoat subscales, which are to be expected given their comparatively weaker bivariate correlations with other measures. These findings lend further support to the moderating, or buffering role of differentiation of self in the relationship between anxiety and triangling, specifically in regard to what appear to be the more aversive types of triangling among adolescents, cross generational coalition and mediation.

This study also investigated the relationship between individuals' psychological symptoms and their self-designated triangle configurations and it supported some of the conjecture about the differences among the four subscales of the TRI in terms of symptomatic outcomes. When using the triangle depictions, the mean symptom score of the Balanced group was lower than those in the Cross-generational coalition or Mediator groups, as predicted, although differences between Mediator and Balanced only approached statistical significance, likely due to the similarities between these configurations (i.e., both assume equal distances between adolescent and parents, but the mediator position involves a higher level of being caught between). Using the TRI, bivariate correlations with our symptom measure showed that the Cross-generational and Mediator subscales showed the strongest and only statistically significant relationships with distress. These findings support previous research regarding the negative effects of Cross-generational coalition and Mediator configurations as it pertains to individuals' levels of depression, school adjustment (Wang et al., 2017), dissatisfaction with parents (Afifi & Schrod, 2003), and relational adjustment (Perrin et al., 2013). However, it should be noted that the measure we used (the HCSL) is a very general measure of distress, which may have precluded the documentation of more nuanced differences.

Limitations

Limitations of the study include the use of convenience sampling via a Midwestern university and various online forums. The large majority of the sample consisted of undergraduate, White females from intact families, which ultimately limits the generalizability of the findings. Whether the relationships among triangling, differentiation, and distress would hold up in samples that are more diverse is an open question. It may be that different triangle types function differently in families other than White, mainly midwestern origin; investigations of these differences would be a fruitful area for future research. In addition, occasional studies seem to find differences across gender in the types of triangling observed and also its effects on outcomes (e.g., Bell et al., 2001), so these comparisons should be closely attended to in future research along with other dimensions of personal identity, such as gender identity. In addition, our method was a one-time survey approach relying solely on self-report

data, which is a further limitation of the study. Because this was a cross sectional study, the ability to draw causal or ordinal inferences is limited. It should be emphasized that the TRI measured current triangling in adolescents' families, rather than triangling in the early family environment. Bowen theory does assert that early triangling that leads to lower levels of differentiation of self, implying a different ordering of the variables than the one we tested. However, we would assert that Bowen theory predicts that differentiation levels (in combination with current levels of stress or anxiety) determine whether individuals will be involved in triangles later in life, in this case late adolescence. These last points illustrate the difficulty of operationalizing and testing a complex construct such as differentiation of self, and indeed, we would observe, the sometimes less than precise predictions of Bowen theory.

The TRI is a recently developed measure of triangling that would benefit from further research. Correlations of the TRI subscales with symptoms, differentiation, and anxiety varied widely. More specifically, smaller correlations were observed for the Scapegoat and Balance subscales in comparison with those of the Mediator and Cross-generational subscales. These variations could represent issues with convergent validity that may be limiting the scale as a whole, or that the positive aspects of these scales are diminishing correlations with distress. Although there was initial evidence of reliability and validity of the TRI, as noted previously, future research is still needed across more diverse samples, specifically regarding gender, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and family structure. Finally, although our analyses were sufficient to document the presence of the hypothesized moderation effect, more sophisticated analyses, such as structural equation modeling, might yield more complex and interesting results.

Implications

Regarding theoretical implications, our results support Kerr and Bowen's (1988) contention that that differentiation of self serves as a protective factor in which those higher in differentiation are more apt to tolerate anxiety, and are thereby less likely to be engaged in triangling than those at lower levels of differentiation of self. Our study was designed to assess the effects of different triangle configurations using a measure specifically designed to assess them, demonstrating that, consistent with theoretical speculations, certain triangle configurations (i.e., Mediator, Cross-generational coalition) are associated with more negative psychological outcomes than others. It will be important to continue conceptualizing triangling as a more nuanced family dynamic that can take a variety of forms rather than as a globally conceptualized, fundamentally harmful, process. As such, it will also be relevant to examine the possible positive outcomes associated with triangling suggested by some, such as Satir et al. (1991).

The results of this study also offer potential clinical implications regarding the value of interventions aimed at increasing family members' level of differentiation of self and decreasing persistent triangling. Given its buffering effect, targeting level of differentiation of self (e.g., increasing objectivity, controlling emotional reactions, learning to take I-position) would likely have positive, long-term effects; interventions increasing differentiation might decrease the frequency of triangling. Although Bowen thought that it was a somewhat slow and arduous process to increase differentiation of self, he did contend that such work was critical, and some research has indicated that such change was feasible (Griffin & Apostol, 1993; Messina et al., 2018). In addition, some approaches to family intervention point to disrupting triangling as an early intervention that can be helpful to decrease symptoms, suggesting that research in this area might more fully guide such interventions (Guerin & Guerin, 2002). In addition, this study highlights the importance of identifying the types of triangling individuals are experiencing. Clinicians could be on the lookout, in particular, for the mediator and cross-generational triangle configurations. Finally, our research suggests that to fully understand systemic functioning, it is important to assess the joint effects of anxiety and DoS in psychological outcomes.

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